

Australia — the most successful side in the competition with six titles — is also emerging from the shadows of some illustrious names in its ranks. Meg Lanning's shoes as captain are yet to be satisfactorily filled. Injury-prone but talismanic left-arm spinner Sophie Molineux has been handed the armband after Alyssa Healy's retirement and has had her workload managed even after the elevation. Probably not the best situation to be in if the biggest question around that call is whether one's captain will be fit enough for the entire tournament.

South Africa is the most exciting side in the tournament this time. Finalist in the last two editions of the T20 World Cup and the 2025 ODI World Cup, the Proteas are desperate for glory. That desperation drew two disillusioned veterans out of international retirement (Shabnim Ismail and Dane van Niekerk), infusing them with new purpose. A 4-1 thrashing of India in the T20I series gone by will be a confidence booster the side needs heading into the tournament.

The Laura Wolvaardt-led side isn't without its jitters with the bat, especially when the seniors in the top order falter, but it is one of the more well-rounded units across departments in this format and therefore primed to make the knockouts. Head coach Mandla Mashimbyi declared that South Africa is picturing itself at Lord's, the venue of the final, already.

Stage fright

England, as evidenced by the series against India, is dealing with several demons, the most urgent being a batting philosophy pulled from the 2010s. The absence of Nat Sciver-Brunt (**right**) has so far rendered the side rather toothless with the bat, but it is also worrying to see just how much heavy lifting the England skipper is doing in that order.

Youngsters like Freya Kemp, who bring a brisk striking ability to the side, have much to teach some of the



Final flourish: This is set to be the last hurrah for New Zealand's golden trio of Suzie Bates, Sophie Devine, and Lea Tahuhu.

more established members higher up the order, and it will be a wrinkle coach Charlotte Edwards would want to iron out as soon as possible. That the host finds itself in a more forgiving group alongside New Zealand will come as a relief to both sides.

The England and Wales Cricket Board, much like Australia did with the 2020 edition and South Africa did in 2023, has set some ambitious audience engagement and attendance targets to galvanise the ecosystem's priorities to include profitability alongside parity.

The last two hosts did well to hold up their end of the bargain by making the final — Australia even thrashed India to send a roaring 86,174-strong MCG into a tizzy. It remains to be seen if England will deliver this time.

As for India, one might even hope for a 'correction' to the storyline of 2017 and an era-defining T20 triumph to complete the nation's white-ball cabinet. An exciting English summer awaits.

